PROBLEM 49

Particle on a Rotating Sphere Attracted to a Point

Original statement · Problems.pdf, p. 34

Relative Equilibria & Bifurcation

A point particle P of mass m slides without friction on a sphere of radius a centered at the origin of the inertial reference frame S_0 as shown in the figure. The particle is attracted by a point A in the equatorial plane, located a distance a from the surface of the sphere as shown. The force of attraction is linearly proportional [sic] the distance between this point and P, with known constant of proportionality $k > 0$. The sphere and the point A rotate rigidly about the vertical with a known angular velocity $\Omega \mathbf{k}_0$. We define the auxiliary reference frame S_1 that rotates with the sphere and point A, with $\mathbf{k}_1 = \mathbf{k}_0$ and $\mathbf{i}_1$ pointing in the direction of A. We introduce the angles ϕ and θ as shown to locate P on the sphere. Note that there is no gravity in this problem.

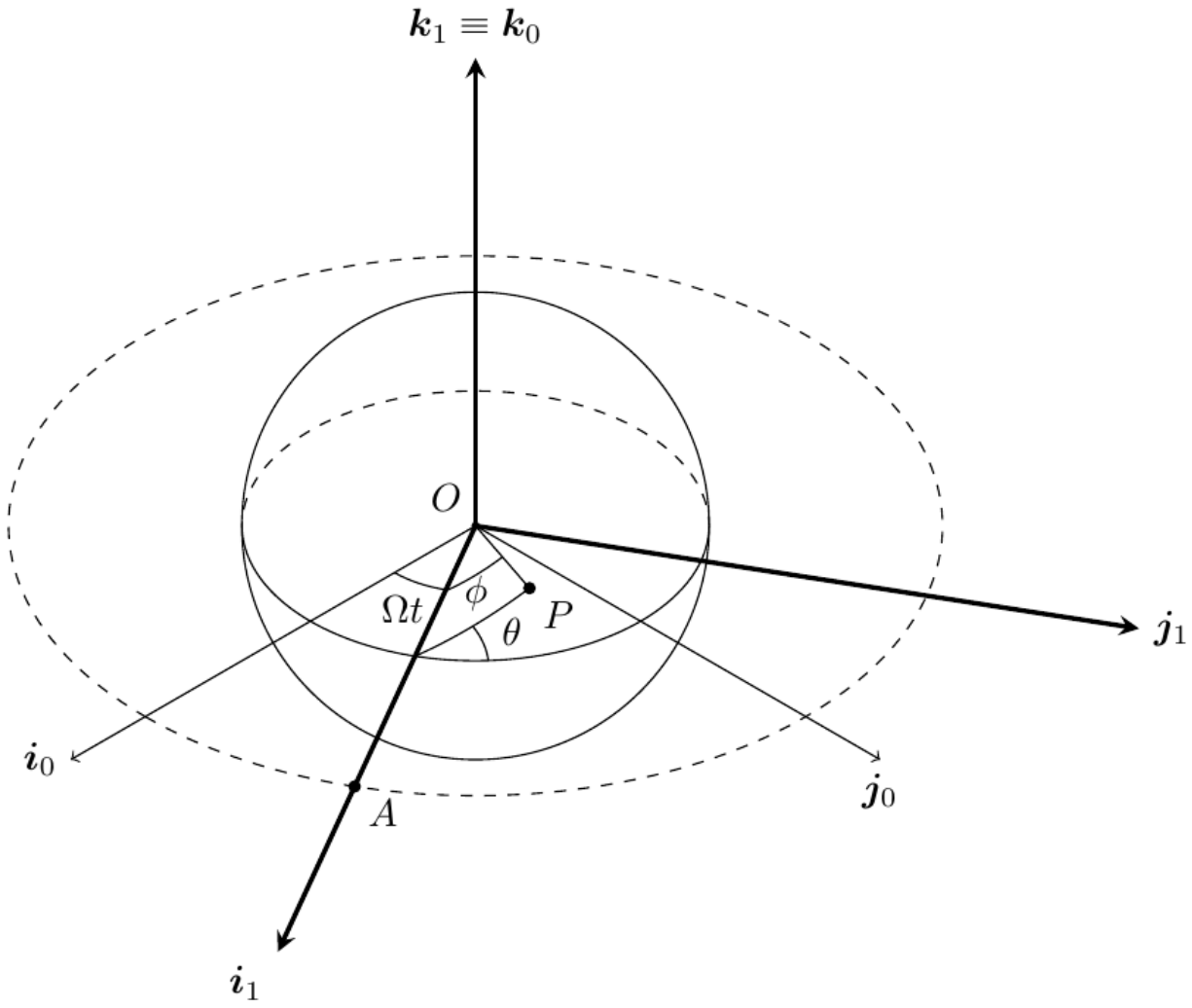


Figure: Sphere of radius a centred at O, point A on the i1 axis outside the sphere in the equatorial plane, particle P located by the angles phi and theta, frame S1 rotated by Omega t about k0 = k1 (Problems.pdf, p. 34).

(a) Express the position, velocity, and acceleration of P with respect to S_1 in terms of ϕ, θ and their derivatives. Remember to define any unit vectors that you want to use in terms of $\mathbf{i}_0, \mathbf{j}_0, \mathbf{k}_0$ first.

(b) Write down the (vector) equation of motion of P in S_1, and derive from there a set of two scalar second-order differential equations for ϕ, θ that do not depend on any other unknowns. To do so, first identify and write down all the forces needed in your analysis.

(c) Is the mechanical energy of P conserved in S_1? Explain. If so, write down the corresponding conservation law.

(d)

Identify all equilibrium configurations of the system, and discuss them as a function of the ratio $m\Omega^2/k$.

(e) Assuming the functions of time $\phi(t)$ and $\theta(t)$ are known, write down the expression of the reaction of the sphere on P.

Worked Solution (4-Phase Methodology)

PHASE 1

Constraints, Degrees of Freedom & Coordinates

- **Physical system:** a particle P of mass m slides on a smooth sphere of radius a centred at O. A point A of the equatorial plane, at distance a from the surface (so $OA = 2a$), attracts P with the force $k\,\overrightarrow{PA}$. Sphere and A rotate rigidly about the vertical with angular velocity $\Omega\,\mathbf{k}_0$. No gravity.
- **Hypotheses:**
  1. $S_0 = \{O; \mathbf{i}_0, \mathbf{j}_0, \mathbf{k}_0\}$ is inertial; Ω is constant.
  2. The sphere is smooth and the contact bilateral: the reaction is radial, $\mathbf{N} = N\,\mathbf{e}_r$ with N of either sign.
  3. **Reading of the figure (angles):** ϕ is the angle at O between $\overrightarrow{OA}$ (i.e. $\mathbf{i}_1$) and $\overrightarrow{OP}$; θ is the angle, measured about the axis OA, between the plane containing $\mathbf{i}_1$ and $\overrightarrow{OP}$ and the equatorial plane (the figure draws it at the point where OA crosses the sphere, between the equator and the arc through P). So ϕ is a polar angle about the axis OA and θ the corresponding azimuth, with $\theta = 0$ in the equatorial plane on the side of $\mathbf{j}_1$ and $\theta = \pi/2$ in the upper hemisphere.
- **Why S_1:** in S_1 both the sphere and the attracting point A are fixed, so the attraction depends only on the position of P and the problem has no explicit time dependence; the inertia forces (Notes Eq. 4.62) take that role. With polar axis OA, the distance AP depends on ϕ only, which keeps the attraction simple.

Symbol	Meaning	SI unit
m	mass of P	kg
a	radius of the sphere ($OA = 2a$)	m
k	attraction constant	N/m

Symbol	Meaning	SI unit
Ω	angular rate of sphere and A	rad/s
ϕ, θ	polar angle from OA, azimuth about OA	rad
N	normal reaction	N
$\Lambda = m\Omega^2/k$	ratio of centrifugal to attraction stiffness	1

PHASE 2

Reference Frames & Vector Bases

- **Frames:** $S_0 = \{O; \mathcal{B}_0\}$ inertial; $S_1 = \{O; \mathcal{B}_1\}$ rotating with the sphere, $\mathbf{k}_1 = \mathbf{k}_0$, $\mathbf{i}_1$ along $\overrightarrow{OA}$. The figure measures Ωt from $\mathbf{i}_0$ to $\mathbf{i}_1$:

$$\mathbf{i}_1 = \cos\Omega t\,\mathbf{i}_0 + \sin\Omega t\,\mathbf{j}_0, \qquad \mathbf{j}_1 = -\sin\Omega t\,\mathbf{i}_0 + \cos\Omega t\,\mathbf{j}_0, \qquad \mathbf{k}_1 = \mathbf{k}_0$$

$$[{}_0R_1] = \begin{pmatrix} \cos\Omega t & -\sin\Omega t & 0 \\ \sin\Omega t & \cos\Omega t & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \qquad \det[{}_0R_1] = \cos^2\Omega t + \sin^2\Omega t = 1$$

The rows are unit vectors and the first two are orthogonal ($\cos\Omega t\sin\Omega t - \sin\Omega t\cos\Omega t = 0$), so $[{}_0R_1][{}_0R_1]^T = I$.

- **Motion of S_1: $\mathbf{a}_0^O = \mathbf{0}$, $\boldsymbol{\omega}_{10} = \Omega\,\mathbf{k}_1$** (simple rotation, Slide 16), $\boldsymbol{\alpha}_{10} = \mathbf{0}$. The attracting point is $\mathbf{r}_1^A = 2a\,\mathbf{i}_1$.
- **Spherical basis with polar axis $\mathbf{i}_1$.** Let $\mathbf{u}(\theta) = \cos\theta\,\mathbf{j}_1 + \sin\theta\,\mathbf{k}_1$ (unit vector of the plane $\mathbf{j}_1\mathbf{k}_1$). Then

$$\mathbf{e}_r = \cos\phi\,\mathbf{i}_1 + \sin\phi\,\mathbf{u} = \cos\phi\,\mathbf{i}_1 + \sin\phi\cos\theta\,\mathbf{j}_1 + \sin\phi\sin\theta\,\mathbf{k}_1$$

$$\mathbf{e}_\phi = \frac{\partial \mathbf{e}_r}{\partial \phi} = -\sin\phi\,\mathbf{i}_1 + \cos\phi\cos\theta\,\mathbf{j}_1 + \cos\phi\sin\theta\,\mathbf{k}_1, \qquad \mathbf{e}_\theta = \frac{d\mathbf{u}}{d\theta} = -\sin\theta\,\mathbf{j}_1 + \cos\theta\,\mathbf{k}_1$$

with $\mathbf{i}_1, \mathbf{j}_1, \mathbf{k}_1$ given above in terms of $\mathcal{B}_0$. The triad is orthonormal and right-handed: $\mathbf{e}_r \times \mathbf{e}_\phi = \left(\cos^2\phi + \sin^2\phi\right)\mathbf{i}_1 \times \mathbf{u} = \cos\theta\,\mathbf{k}_1 - \sin\theta\,\mathbf{j}_1 = \mathbf{e}_\theta$, hence also $\mathbf{e}_\phi \times \mathbf{e}_\theta = \mathbf{e}_r$, $\mathbf{e}_\theta \times \mathbf{e}_r = \mathbf{e}_\phi$. Inverse relations used below: $\mathbf{u} = \sin\phi\,\mathbf{e}_r + \cos\phi\,\mathbf{e}_\phi$, so

$$\mathbf{i}_1 = \cos\phi\,\mathbf{e}_r - \sin\phi\,\mathbf{e}_\phi, \qquad \mathbf{k}_1 = \sin\theta\,\mathbf{u} + \cos\theta\,\mathbf{e}_\theta = \sin\phi\sin\theta\,\mathbf{e}_r + \cos\phi\sin\theta\,\mathbf{e}_\phi + \cos\theta\,\mathbf{e}_\theta$$

PHASE 3

Derivation

3.1 Kinematics

(a) Position, velocity and acceleration in S_1

Pedagogical Justification: $\mathbf{r}_1^P = a\,\mathbf{e}_r$ (Notes Eq. 3.16 with the origin O common to both frames). The relative derivative keeps $\mathbf{i}_1, \mathbf{j}_1, \mathbf{k}_1$ fixed, so the spherical vectors change only through $\phi(t)$ and $\theta(t)$ (chain rule).

Time derivatives of the basis in S_1:

$$\left.\frac{d\mathbf{e}_r}{dt}\right|_1 = -\sin\phi\,\dot\phi\,\mathbf{i}_1 + \cos\phi\,\dot\phi\,\mathbf{u} + \sin\phi\,\frac{d\mathbf{u}}{d\theta}\dot\theta = \dot\phi\,\mathbf{e}_\phi + \sin\phi\,\dot\theta\,\mathbf{e}_\theta$$

$$\left.\frac{d\mathbf{e}_\phi}{dt}\right|_1 = -\cos\phi\,\dot\phi\,\mathbf{i}_1 - \sin\phi\,\dot\phi\,\mathbf{u} + \cos\phi\,\dot\theta\,\mathbf{e}_\theta = -\dot\phi\,\mathbf{e}_r + \cos\phi\,\dot\theta\,\mathbf{e}_\theta$$

$$\left.\frac{d\mathbf{e}_\theta}{dt}\right|_1 = \dot\theta\,(-\cos\theta\,\mathbf{j}_1 - \sin\theta\,\mathbf{k}_1) = -\dot\theta\,\mathbf{u} = -\sin\phi\,\dot\theta\,\mathbf{e}_r - \cos\phi\,\dot\theta\,\mathbf{e}_\phi$$

Position and velocity:

$$\mathbf{r}_1^P = a\,\mathbf{e}_r, \qquad \mathbf{v}_1^P = a\left.\frac{d\mathbf{e}_r}{dt}\right|_1 = a\dot{\phi}\,\mathbf{e}_\phi + a\sin\phi\,\dot{\theta}\,\mathbf{e}_\theta$$

Acceleration, by the product rule on each term, $\frac{d}{dt}(a\dot{\phi}\,\mathbf{e}_\phi) = a\ddot{\phi}\,\mathbf{e}_\phi + a\dot{\phi}\left(-\dot{\phi}\,\mathbf{e}_r + \cos\phi\,\dot{\theta}\,\mathbf{e}_\theta\right)$ and $\frac{d}{dt}(a\sin\phi\,\dot{\theta}\,\mathbf{e}_\theta) = a\left(\cos\phi\,\dot{\phi}\dot{\theta} + \sin\phi\,\ddot{\theta}\right)\mathbf{e}_\theta + a\sin\phi\,\dot{\theta}\left(-\sin\phi\,\dot{\theta}\,\mathbf{e}_r - \cos\phi\,\dot{\theta}\,\mathbf{e}_\phi\right)$; collecting:

$$\mathbf{a}_1^P = -a\left(\dot{\phi}^2 + \sin^2\phi\,\dot{\theta}^2\right)\mathbf{e}_r + a\left(\ddot{\phi} - \sin\phi\cos\phi\,\dot{\theta}^2\right)\mathbf{e}_\phi + a\left(\sin\phi\,\ddot{\theta} + 2\cos\phi\,\dot{\phi}\dot{\theta}\right)\mathbf{e}_\theta$$

3.2 Forces

(b) Forces on the particle (the vector equation and the scalar equations follow in 3.3)

> **Pedagogical Justification:** in S_1, $m\mathbf{a}_1^P = \mathbf{F} + \mathbf{F}_i$ (Notes Eq. 4.63). The actual forces are the attraction and the reaction; the inertia forces (Notes Eq. 4.62) reduce to the centrifugal and Coriolis forces because $\mathbf{a}_0^O = \mathbf{0}$ and $\boldsymbol{\alpha}_{10} = \mathbf{0}$.

Attraction: $\mathbf{F}_k = k\left(\mathbf{r}_1^A - \mathbf{r}_1^P\right) = k\left(2a\,\mathbf{i}_1 - a\,\mathbf{e}_r\right)$; with $\mathbf{i}_1 = \cos\phi\,\mathbf{e}_r - \sin\phi\,\mathbf{e}_\phi$,

$$\mathbf{F}_k = ka\left(2\cos\phi - 1\right)\mathbf{e}_r - 2ka\sin\phi\,\mathbf{e}_\phi$$

Reaction: $\mathbf{N} = N\,\mathbf{e}_r$.

Centrifugal force. With the identity $\mathbf{a}\times(\mathbf{b}\times\mathbf{c}) = (\mathbf{a}\cdot\mathbf{c})\mathbf{b} - (\mathbf{a}\cdot\mathbf{b})\mathbf{c}$ (Slide 30): $\boldsymbol{\omega}_{10}\times\left(\boldsymbol{\omega}_{10}\times\mathbf{r}_1^P\right) = \Omega^2 z_1\,\mathbf{k}_1 - \Omega^2\mathbf{r}_1^P$, where $z_1 = \mathbf{r}_1^P\cdot\mathbf{k}_1 = a\sin\phi\sin\theta$. Hence $\mathbf{F}_C = m\Omega^2\left(\mathbf{r}_1^P - z_1\mathbf{k}_1\right)$, and with $\mathbf{k}_1$ in the spherical basis:

$$\mathbf{F}_C = m\Omega^2 a\left[\left(1 - \sin^2\phi\sin^2\theta\right)\mathbf{e}_r - \sin^2\theta\sin\phi\cos\phi\,\mathbf{e}_\phi - \sin\phi\sin\theta\cos\theta\,\mathbf{e}_\theta\right]$$

Coriolis force. Using $\mathbf{k}_1 = \sin\phi\sin\theta\,\mathbf{e}_r + \cos\phi\sin\theta\,\mathbf{e}_\phi + \cos\theta\,\mathbf{e}_\theta$ and the cyclic products of the right-handed triad:

$$\mathbf{k}_1 \times \mathbf{e}_\phi = \sin\phi\sin\theta\,\mathbf{e}_r \times \mathbf{e}_\phi + \cos\theta\,\mathbf{e}_\theta \times \mathbf{e}_\phi = \sin\phi\sin\theta\,\mathbf{e}_\theta - \cos\theta\,\mathbf{e}_r$$

$$\mathbf{k}_1 \times \mathbf{e}_\theta = \sin\phi\sin\theta\,\mathbf{e}_r \times \mathbf{e}_\theta + \cos\phi\sin\theta\,\mathbf{e}_\phi \times \mathbf{e}_\theta = -\sin\phi\sin\theta\,\mathbf{e}_\phi + \cos\phi\sin\theta\,\mathbf{e}_r$$

$$\mathbf{F}_{COR} = -2m\Omega\,\mathbf{k}_1 \times \left(a\dot{\phi}\,\mathbf{e}_\phi + a\sin\phi\,\dot{\theta}\,\mathbf{e}_\theta\right) = 2m\Omega a\left[\left(\cos\theta\,\dot{\phi} - \sin\theta\sin\phi\cos\phi\,\dot{\theta}\right)\mathbf{e}_r + \sin\theta\sin^2\phi\,\dot{\theta}\,\mathbf{e}_\phi - \sin\theta\sin\phi\,\dot{\phi}\,\mathbf{e}_\theta\right]$$

3.3 Equations of Motion

(b, continued) Vector equation and scalar equations

Vector equation of motion in S_1:

$$m\mathbf{a}_1^P = k\left(\mathbf{r}_1^A - \mathbf{r}_1^P\right) + N\,\mathbf{e}_r - m\boldsymbol{\omega}_{10} \times \left(\boldsymbol{\omega}_{10} \times \mathbf{r}_1^P\right) - 2m\boldsymbol{\omega}_{10} \times \mathbf{v}_1^P$$

Scalar equations free of N: project on $\mathbf{e}_\phi$ and $\mathbf{e}_\theta$, which are perpendicular to $\mathbf{N}$:

$$\boxed{ma\left(\ddot{\phi} - \sin\phi\cos\phi\,\dot{\theta}^2\right) = -2ka\sin\phi - m\Omega^2 a\sin^2\theta\sin\phi\cos\phi + 2m\Omega a\sin\theta\sin^2\phi\,\dot{\theta}}$$

$$\boxed{ma\left(\sin\phi\,\ddot{\theta} + 2\cos\phi\,\dot{\phi}\dot{\theta}\right) = -m\Omega^2 a\sin\phi\sin\theta\cos\theta - 2m\Omega a\sin\theta\sin\phi\,\dot{\phi}}$$

3.4 Integration and Answers

(c) Conservation of mechanical energy in S_1

> **Pedagogical Justification:** yes, E_1^P is conserved. The sphere is fixed in S_1 and smooth, so $\mathbf{N}\cdot\mathbf{v}_1^P = 0$ ($\mathbf{v}_1^P$ has no $\mathbf{e}_r$ component); $\mathbf{F}_{COR}\cdot\mathbf{v}_1^P = 0$ (Slide 31); the Euler force and $-m\mathbf{a}_0^O$ are zero; the attraction towards the point A, fixed in S_1, is conservative with $V_k = \frac{1}{2}k\left|\mathbf{r}_1^P - \mathbf{r}_1^A\right|^2$; and the centrifugal force has $V_C = -\frac{1}{2}m\Omega^2 r_\perp^2$ because $\boldsymbol{\omega}_{10}$ is constant (Slide 30).

Potentials on the sphere:

$$\left|\mathbf{r}_1^P - \mathbf{r}_1^A\right|^2 = a^2 - 4a^2\,\mathbf{e}_r\cdot\mathbf{i}_1 + 4a^2 = 5a^2 - 4a^2\cos\phi \;\Rightarrow\; V_k = \frac{5}{2}ka^2 - 2ka^2\cos\phi$$

$$r_\perp^2 = x_1^2 + y_1^2 = a^2 - z_1^2 = a^2 - a^2\sin^2\phi\sin^2\theta \;\Rightarrow\; V_C = -\frac{1}{2}m\Omega^2a^2 + \frac{1}{2}m\Omega^2a^2\sin^2\phi\sin^2\theta$$

Dropping the constants, with $T_1^P = \frac{1}{2}m\left|\mathbf{v}_1^P\right|^2 = \frac{1}{2}ma^2\left(\dot\phi^2 + \sin^2\phi\,\dot\theta^2\right)$:

$$\boxed{E_1^P = \frac{1}{2}ma^2\left(\dot\phi^2 + \sin^2\phi\,\dot\theta^2\right) - 2ka^2\cos\phi + \frac{1}{2}m\Omega^2a^2\sin^2\phi\sin^2\theta = \text{const}}$$

Check. Differentiating with the chain and product rules ($\frac{d}{dt}\sin^2\phi = 2\sin\phi\cos\phi\,\dot\phi$, $\frac{d}{dt}\sin^2\theta = 2\sin\theta\cos\theta\,\dot\theta$) and grouping:

$$\frac{dE_1^P}{dt} = a\dot\phi\left[ma\left(\ddot\phi - \sin\phi\cos\phi\,\dot\theta^2\right) + 2ka\sin\phi + m\Omega^2a\sin^2\theta\sin\phi\cos\phi\right] + a\sin\phi\,\dot\theta\left[ma\left(\sin\phi\,\ddot\theta + 2\cos\phi\,\dot\phi\dot\theta\right) + m\Omega^2a\sin\phi\sin\theta\cos\theta\right]$$

By the equations of (b) the brackets equal $2m\Omega a\sin\theta\sin^2\phi\,\dot\theta$ and $-2m\Omega a\sin\theta\sin\phi\,\dot\phi$, so

$$\frac{dE_1^P}{dt} = 2m\Omega a^2\sin\theta\sin^2\phi\,\dot\phi\dot\theta - 2m\Omega a^2\sin\theta\sin^2\phi\,\dot\phi\dot\theta = 0$$

which is exactly $\mathbf{F}_{COR} \cdot \mathbf{v}_1^P = 0$. The constant is fixed by initial conditions (not given).

(d) Equilibrium configurations

> **Pedagogical Justification:** a relative equilibrium has $\dot\phi = \dot\theta = \ddot\phi = \ddot\theta = 0$, so the right-hand sides of the equations of (b) must vanish (the Coriolis terms disappear). The points $\phi = 0, \pi$ are the poles of the coordinates (θ undefined there) and must be examined separately; the symbolic check confirms the list below with Cartesian coordinates and a Lagrange multiplier.

With $\Lambda = m\Omega^2/k$, the two conditions are

$$\sin\phi\left(2k + m\Omega^2 \sin^2\theta\cos\phi\right) = 0 \iff \sin\phi\left(2 + \Lambda\sin^2\theta\cos\phi\right) = 0, \qquad \sin\phi\sin\theta\cos\theta = 0$$

- $\sin\phi = 0$**:** both are satisfied. **E1:** $\phi = 0$, $\mathbf{r}_1^P = a\,\mathbf{i}_1$, the point of the sphere nearest to A. **E2:** $\phi = \pi$, $\mathbf{r}_1^P = -a\,\mathbf{i}_1$, the point farthest from A. They exist for every Λ: at both, the attraction and the centrifugal force are radial (along $\pm\mathbf{i}_1$) and the reaction balances them.
- $\sin\phi \neq 0$**:** the second condition needs $\sin\theta = 0$ or $\cos\theta = 0$. If $\sin\theta = 0$, the first becomes $2 = 0$: impossible. If $\cos\theta = 0$ ($\theta = \pm\pi/2$, $\sin^2\theta = 1$), the first gives

$$\cos\phi^* = -\frac{2k}{m\Omega^2} = -\frac{2}{\Lambda}$$

which has a solution with $\sin\phi^* \neq 0$ only if $\Lambda > 2$. **E3, E4** ($\theta = \pm\pi/2$):

$$\mathbf{r}_1^P = -\frac{2a}{\Lambda}\,\mathbf{i}_1 \pm a\sqrt{1 - \frac{4}{\Lambda^2}}\,\mathbf{k}_1$$

They lie in the meridian plane $\mathbf{i}_1\mathbf{k}_1$ that contains A, on the hemisphere opposite to A, symmetric above and below the equator.

Discussion in terms of $m\Omega^2/k$:

- $\Lambda = m\Omega^2/k \leq 2$: only E1 and E2.
- $\Lambda > 2$: E1, E2, E3 and E4. As $\Lambda \to 2^+$, $\cos\phi^* \to -1$ and E3, E4 merge into E2 (a pitchfork bifurcation); as $\Lambda \to \infty$, $\cos\phi^* \to 0$ and they tend to the poles $\pm a\,\mathbf{k}_1$.

Extension (stability, beyond what is asked). Near E1, $V_1 \approx \text{const} + k\left(y_1^2 + z_1^2\right) + \frac{1}{2}m\Omega^2 z_1^2$, a strict minimum, so E1 is stable for every Λ (energy argument). Near E2, $V_1 \approx \text{const} - k y_1^2 + \left(\frac{1}{2}m\Omega^2 - k\right) z_1^2$; along $\mathbf{j}_1$ the linearised motion is $m\ddot{y}_1 = 2ky_1$ (no Coriolis coupling there, because $\mathbf{k}_1 \times \mathbf{v}_1^P$ is normal to the sphere at E2), so E2 is always unstable with growth rate $\sqrt{2k/m}$. E3 and E4 are maxima of V_1; the linearisation including the Coriolis terms (computed numerically for several values $\Lambda > 2$) has eigenvalues with positive real part, so they are unstable as well.

(e) Reaction of the sphere

> **Pedagogical Justification:** the projection of the vector equation on $\mathbf{e}_r$ contains N and only known functions once $\phi(t), \theta(t)$ are known.

$$-ma\left(\dot{\phi}^2 + \sin^2\phi\,\dot{\theta}^2\right) = N + ka\left(2\cos\phi - 1\right) + m\Omega^2 a\left(1 - \sin^2\phi\sin^2\theta\right) + 2m\Omega a\left(\cos\theta\,\dot{\phi} - \sin\theta\sin\phi\cos\phi\,\dot{\theta}\right)$$

$$\boxed{\mathbf{N} = -\left[ma\left(\dot{\phi}^2 + \sin^2\phi\,\dot{\theta}^2\right) + ka\left(2\cos\phi - 1\right) + m\Omega^2 a\left(1 - \sin^2\phi\sin^2\theta\right) + 2m\Omega a\left(\cos\theta\,\dot{\phi} - \sin\theta\sin\phi\cos\phi\,\dot{\theta}\right)\right]\mathbf{e}_r}$$

with $\mathbf{e}_r = \cos\phi\,\mathbf{i}_1 + \sin\phi\cos\theta\,\mathbf{j}_1 + \sin\phi\sin\theta\,\mathbf{k}_1$ and $\mathbf{i}_1, \mathbf{j}_1, \mathbf{k}_1$ in terms of $\mathcal{B}_0$ from Phase 2.

PHASE 4

Interpretation & Checks

- **Competition of two effects:** the attraction pulls P towards the point nearest A (E1), and its tangential part has stiffness $\sim k$; the centrifugal force pushes P away from the vertical axis with stiffness $\sim m\Omega^2$. The ratio $\Lambda = m\Omega^2/k$ decides whether, on the far side of the sphere, the centrifugal push towards the equator can be balanced by the attraction: only for $\Lambda > 2$ do the extra equilibria E3, E4 appear.
- **Reaction at E1:** with $\phi = 0$ and no motion, $N = -ka - m\Omega^2 a$: the sphere pulls P inwards, since both the attraction (towards A, outside the sphere) and the centrifugal force push P outwards. The bilateral contact assumed in Phase 1 is needed for that.
- **Limit $\Omega \to 0$:** the inertia forces vanish, $\Lambda \to 0$, and only E1 (stable) and E2 (unstable) remain, as for a fixed sphere with a fixed attracting point.
- **Dimensions:** in the $\mathbf{e}_\phi$ equation, $[ma\ddot{\phi}] = \text{kg m s}^{-2} = \text{N}$, $[ka] = \text{N}$, $[m\Omega^2 a] = \text{N}$, $[m\Omega a\dot{\theta}] = \text{N}$; $[E_1^P] = [ka^2] = [m\Omega^2 a^2] = \text{J}$; $\Lambda = \text{kg s}^{-2}/(\text{N/m})$ is dimensionless.

- **Check against the official key:** none for this problem (Problems.pdf, p. 76 lists no answer for 49).
- **Symbolic check (sympy):** $\mathbf{a}_0^P$ from differentiating $\left[{}_0R_1\right]\mathbf{r}_1^P$ twice equals the Notes Eq. 3.27 decomposition; the force components, both equations of motion, the reaction and $dE_1^P/dt = 0$ are confirmed; the equilibria found with Cartesian coordinates and a Lagrange multiplier are exactly E1 to E4.

Source: Problems.pdf (PDF page 34); no official key